

Why a Coherent Worldview Can Become Less True

Epistemic Drift, Representational Hardening, and Sensemaking

Reality Drift Framework — Short Concept Note #2

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The Basic Pattern

A worldview helps organize experience.

It connects events.

Explains causes.

Separates signal from noise.

Provides categories for interpreting what happens.

At first, the model remains responsive to observation.

New evidence changes the structure.

Contradictions create pressure.

Uncertainty remains visible.

Over time, the worldview can become more internally coherent while becoming less responsive to the reality it was built to explain.

The core sequence is:

observation → interpretation → explanatory model → internal coherence → self-reinforcement → epistemic drift

A Worldview Is a Representation

No person encounters reality without interpretation.

Experience is filtered through concepts, expectations, language, memory, and prior belief.

A worldview organizes these elements into a relatively stable representation of how the world works.

It identifies important objects.

Names recurring patterns.

Assigns causes.

Creates relationships between events.

Provides expectations about what will happen next.

This representation is necessary.

Without it, every experience would appear isolated and difficult to interpret.

The problem begins when the representation becomes harder to revise than the reality it represents.

Why Coherence Feels Like Truth

A coherent worldview reduces contradiction.

Its concepts fit together.

Its explanations reinforce one another.

New events can be placed inside an existing structure.

This creates a powerful sense of understanding.

The model feels complete because fewer experiences remain unexplained.

But coherence is an internal property.

It describes how well the elements of a representation fit together.

Truth requires a second relationship.

The representation must also remain answerable to conditions outside itself.

A worldview can become increasingly coherent while losing contact with those conditions.

Coherence Is Not Contact

A model may explain every event because it is accurate.

It may also explain every event because it has become difficult to challenge.

Supporting evidence confirms the model.

Contradictory evidence proves that others are confused.

Missing evidence becomes evidence of concealment.

Failed predictions are reinterpreted as deeper confirmation.

Every possible outcome can be absorbed.

The model no longer risks being wrong.

Its coherence increases because external correction has weakened.

Coherence is not contact.

Epistemic Drift

Epistemic Drift occurs when a system of belief remains internally organized while gradually losing responsiveness to the reality it claims to explain.

The worldview does not necessarily become irrational.

Its individual claims may remain plausible.

Its language may become more precise.

Its explanations may become more sophisticated.

The drift appears in the weakening relationship between interpretation and correction.

The worldview continues producing meaning.

Reality becomes less capable of changing it.

From Interpretation to Explanatory Infrastructure

A worldview often begins as a provisional interpretation.

It helps make sense of a limited set of observations.

Over time, more concepts are added.

The model becomes connected to identity, community, expertise, memory, and moral judgment.

It stops functioning as one possible explanation.

It becomes the structure through which explanations are evaluated.

New information no longer enters an open field.

It must pass through the existing representation.

The model does not merely answer questions.

It determines which questions can be asked.

Representational Hardening

Representational Hardening occurs when a revisable interpretation becomes embedded in structures that resist correction.

A tentative concept becomes a stable category.

The category becomes part of a larger theory.

The theory becomes a public commitment.

The commitment becomes part of identity.

The worldview becomes costly to revise.

The sequence is:

provisional interpretation → repeated use → conceptual dependence → identity attachment → structural resistance

The representation becomes more durable.

Its durability can be mistaken for validity.

When Categories Begin Controlling Observation

Categories make perception manageable.

They allow different events to be recognized as instances of the same pattern.

But categories also direct attention.

Once a category becomes familiar, the mind begins searching for examples of it.

Ambiguous events are sorted into existing distinctions.

Differences become less visible.

The category begins shaping what can be observed.

A worldview may therefore appear increasingly confirmed because perception has become organized around its terms.

The representation selects the evidence that later appears to validate it.

The Self-Sealing Model

A self-sealing model contains explanations for why it should not be questioned.

Criticism is interpreted as ignorance.

Disagreement is interpreted as bias.

Uncertainty is interpreted as weakness.

Institutional rejection is interpreted as proof of originality.

Lack of recognition is interpreted as suppression.

The model can survive almost any encounter because the encounter is translated into its own vocabulary.

This creates a closed correction loop.

The worldview remains active.

Nothing outside it can exert sufficient pressure to change its structure.

Narrative Compression

Complex events contain many causes, time scales, actors, and uncertainties.

A worldview compresses this complexity into a manageable account.

The compression may be useful.

It identifies the central mechanism.

Removes irrelevant detail.

Makes comparison possible.

But repeated compression can gradually remove the conditions that would complicate the explanation.

Events become examples of the same pattern.

Differences become surface variation.

History becomes evidence for an already known structure.

The worldview becomes easier to apply because less of reality must be retained.

Recursive Interpretation

Once a worldview is established, earlier interpretations become inputs for later ones.

A past event is summarized through the model.

That summary becomes evidence for a broader conclusion.

The broader conclusion shapes how the next event is interpreted.

The new interpretation strengthens the original model.

This is a form of recursive representation.

The worldview increasingly learns from its own previous explanations.

Direct observation remains present.

But it enters a system already populated by compressed interpretations of earlier observations.

Why Intelligence Does Not Prevent Epistemic Drift

Greater intelligence can improve correction.

It can also improve rationalization.

A skilled thinker can identify subtle patterns.

Compare competing explanations.

Detect hidden assumptions.

They can also generate stronger defenses for a preferred model.

Resolve contradictions through increasingly complex interpretation.

Translate disconfirming evidence into supporting evidence.

Build a worldview that is difficult for others to challenge.

The ability to maintain coherence is not the same as the willingness to remain corrigible.

Epistemic Drift can become more sophisticated as reasoning ability increases.

Sensemaking and Closure

Sensemaking reduces uncertainty by placing experience inside an explanatory structure.

This is useful during confusion, complexity, or rapid change.

But sensemaking also creates pressure toward closure.

An unresolved event is cognitively expensive.

A named mechanism feels manageable.

A connected account feels complete.

The desire for orientation can therefore reward explanations before they have been adequately tested.

The worldview succeeds psychologically before it succeeds epistemically.

It restores meaning.

Whether it preserves contact remains a separate question.

Social Reinforcement

Worldviews are rarely maintained by individuals alone.

Communities share vocabulary.

Repeat examples.

Recognize authorities.

Reward particular interpretations.

Create boundaries around acceptable disagreement.

This allows knowledge to accumulate.

It also creates representational environments in which some conclusions become easier to perceive than others.

A belief may feel independently confirmed because it appears across many people and sources.

Those sources may be reproducing the same underlying interpretation.

Social repetition can resemble independent evidence.

The Vocabulary Trap

A strong vocabulary reveals patterns that were previously difficult to name.

Once named, those patterns become easier to recognize and discuss.

But vocabulary can also create premature certainty.

A label may be applied before the mechanism is established.

Naming can be mistaken for explanation.

Different events may appear equivalent because the same term describes them.

The vocabulary begins organizing observation more strongly than observation corrects the vocabulary.

The concept remains useful.

Its boundaries become less visible.

Ontology and Worldview

Every worldview contains an implicit ontology.

It makes claims about what kinds of things exist.

Which entities matter.

What counts as a cause.

Which levels of explanation are fundamental.

What kinds of relationships are possible.

These assumptions are often less visible than individual beliefs.

A person may revise specific conclusions while preserving the ontology that generated them.

The surface interpretation changes.

The deeper representational structure remains stable.

Epistemic correction therefore requires more than replacing incorrect claims.

It may require questioning the categories through which claims become thinkable.

Why the Worldview Still Looks Healthy

Epistemic Drift is difficult to recognize because the worldview often becomes more productive.

It explains more events.

Generates more predictions.

Connects more domains.

Provides clearer language.

Creates stronger identity and community.

Reduces uncertainty.

These are real functions.

They do not prove that the model remains aligned.

A worldview can become more generative inside its own representational environment while becoming less sensitive to conditions outside it.

The absence of contradiction is not proof of contact.

Semantic Fidelity

Semantic Fidelity describes how well a representation preserves the important structure, distinctions, and constraints of what it represents.

A worldview has high semantic fidelity when its concepts clarify reality without erasing the differences that matter.

It has low semantic fidelity when many events can be absorbed only by removing context, ambiguity, or contradiction.

The central question is not whether the worldview can explain an event.

It is whether the explanation preserves enough of the event to remain answerable to it.

A universal explanation can achieve coherence by sacrificing distinction.

Corrigibility

A healthy worldview does not remain permanently uncertain.

It makes commitments.

Forms expectations.

Rejects weaker explanations.

But it preserves routes through which reality can still exert correction.

Predictions can fail.

Categories can be revised.

Exceptions can remain exceptions.

Competing models can explain something better.

The model can lose.

This capacity is **corrigibility**.

Without it, a worldview may continue evolving internally while external feedback loses authority.

A Recognition Test

Ask:

What evidence would meaningfully weaken this worldview?

Can the model distinguish a failed prediction from a misunderstood outcome?

Does every disagreement become evidence of the same underlying mechanism?

Are categories revealing differences or absorbing them?

Can events remain unresolved without being forced into the existing explanation?

Has the worldview become easier to defend than to test?

Do I encounter reality through the model, or mainly encounter interpretations already produced by the model?

These questions test whether coherence remains connected to correction.

Worldviews and Reality Drift

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, a worldview is a representational system.

It organizes experience through concepts, narratives, categories, causal models, and expectations.

As the system becomes more comprehensive, it can mediate a greater portion of what the person encounters.

Reality Drift begins when the worldview remains coherent, productive, and psychologically convincing while becoming less answerable to conditions outside itself.

The model still explains.

The world loses the ability to object.

The Core Principle

A worldview becomes more useful by organizing experience.

It becomes less true when organization replaces correction.

A coherent worldview can become less true when its internal relationships strengthen faster than its contact with external reality.

Epistemic Drift begins when the model continues interpreting the world but the world can no longer meaningfully revise the model.

Representational Hardening turns a provisional explanation into the infrastructure through which all later evidence is judged.

The goal is not to abandon coherence. It is to preserve a form of coherence that remains corrigible.

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